

Δαμάσκιος ὁ Δαμασκηνός

Damascius of Damascus: On Principles and the Platonic School

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Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)

Dialect: Ἀττικίζουσα [Atticizing](#)

Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)

Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)

Affiliation: [Neoplatonist](#)

Damascius was a Neoplatonic philosopher active in the late 5th and early 6th centuries CE. Born in Damascus, he studied in Alexandria before becoming the head of the Platonic school in Athens around 515 CE. His leadership coincided with a period of increasing pressure from the Christian Byzantine state. In 529 CE, Emperor Justinian issued an edict prohibiting pagan teaching, which led to the school's closure.

Damascius, along with several other philosophers, sought refuge at the court of the Persian King Khosrow I in 531/532 CE. A subsequent peace treaty allowed their safe return, and Damascius is believed to have spent his final years in Syria.

His major surviving work is **Problems and Solutions Concerning First Principles**, a dense philosophical treatise that critically examines the core ideas of earlier Neoplatonists like Proclus. Other partially surviving works include commentaries on Plato's **Parmenides** and **Phaedo**. He also wrote the **Life of Isidore**, a biographical account of his teacher that survives in fragments; modern scholars value it as a historical source for the lives of pagan philosophers in a Christianizing empire.

Damascius is historically significant as the last head of the Platonic Academy in Athens. His writings represent the final, sophisticated development of pagan Neoplatonic thought in the ancient world. His critical and questioning approach provides crucial insight into the internal debates of the Athenian school. His exile to Persia and return symbolize the end of institutionalized pagan philosophy in the Greco-Roman world.

Works (7)

- Βίος Ἰσιδώρου · [Bibl. codd. 181, 242](#)), [Life of Isidore](#) · 187 passages
- Περὶ Φαίδωνος · [Commentary on Phaedo \(Long\)](#) · 563 passages
- Περὶ Φαίδωνος · [Commentary on Phaedo \(Short\)](#) · 158 passages
- Βίος Ἰσιδώρου · [Life of Isidore](#) · 365 passages
- Περὶ Παρμενίδου · [On Parmenides](#) · 318 passages
- Περὶ Φιλήβου · [On Philebus](#) · 261 passages
- Περὶ Ἀρχῶν · [On Principles](#) · 328 passages

Other Neoplatonist Authors

- [Ἀμελίου Ἐπιστολή · Amelius Letters](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀμμώνιος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · Ammonius of Alexandria Phil](#) · 5 works
- [Δαβίδ ὁ Ἀνίκητος · David the Invincible](#) · 2 works
- [Δέξιππος ὁ Νεοπλατωνικός · Dexippus the Neoplatonist](#) · 1 work
- [Ἡλίας ὁ Νεοπλατωνικός · Elias the Neoplatonist](#) · 3 works
- [Εὐσέβιος ὁ Μύνδιος · Eusebius of Myndus](#) · 1 work
- [Ἱεροκλῆς ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς · Hierocles of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- [Ἰάμβλιχος ὁ Ἀνώνυμος · Iamblichus Anonymous](#) · 1 work
- [Ἰάμβλιχος ὁ Χαλκιδεὺς · Iamblichus of Chalcis](#) · 6 works
- [Ἰάμβλιχος ὁ Χαλκιδεὺς · Iamblichus of Chalcis II](#) · 1 work
- [Ἰουλιανὸς ὁ Ἀποστάτης · Julian the Apostate](#) · 20 works
- [Μαρτῖνος ὁ Νεαπολίτης · Marinus of Neapolis](#) · 1 work